What about the final P – power? Given the power gap and the prospect that China will pull even further away from India, how far can China go? What is the future of China's power and its role in the international system? Will it challenge and then surpass the US to become the global hegemon?

Virtually all assessments of the Chinese economy are that it will surge past the American economy in nominal GDP terms – the latest projections are that it may move into first place by 2028 as a result of China's continuing economic growth and the US economy's intermittent slowdowns.[9] Most analysts accept that China's GDP has already passed the US's in purchasing power parity or PPP terms: PPP is a method for adjusting nominal GDP figures based on what it costs to buy a similar basket of goods across countries. International relations scholars generally assume economic superiority will gradually turn into military superiority. For Asia, this would mean that China will be not only economically but also militarily dominant and that the US will be under pressure to retrench from the continent.

Opinions are divided on how large the gap between China and the US could become. Among the China optimists is the British journalist Martin Jacques, who argues the inevitability of Chinese hegemony in his book, *When China Rules the World*.[10] Is China destined to be number one and to rule the world? The Princeton political scientist and expert on US grand strategy Aaron L. Friedberg, in his book *A Contest for Supremacy*, thinks Chinese hegemony is not inevitable. Instead, he sees a 'struggle for mastery in Asia' and concludes that the US with various partners can balance China.[11] In June 2016, at a meeting organized by the German Marshall Fund (GMF) and the International Institute of Strategic Studies (IISS), I not very originally argued that Chinese power was advancing steadily and sometimes stealthily. At the end of the session, a tall, rather stern man strode up to me and put a book in my hand, saying, 'You might like to read this.' Before I could react, he was already giving someone else a copy of the book. In my hand was Michael Pillsbury's *The Hundred-Year Marathon: China's Secret Strategy to Replace America as the Global Superpower*.[12] The bearer of the book turned out to be the author himself. In it, like